

winning a great victory after revealing her true identity to her soldiers. Her legend, the inspiration behind many books and a 1998 Disney film, probably has no basis on any single historical individual. However, there are real examples of women fighting while disguised as men, such as Fannu, a 12th-century Moroccan princess who disguised herself to fight off an invading army in Marrakesh. Some women in ancient and medieval times fought openly, even leading armies—such as Chinese Empress Fu Hao, who was a general in her own right.

Taking command

Ancient and medieval women did lead armies across the world. Among those queens who personally commanded their forces was Rudrama Devi, an Indian monarch who died fighting an enemy kingdom in the late 13th century. Women could also hold command in the absence of a male leader. Blanche of Castile, for example, who served as French regent from 1226–1236 CE personally led the royal army. Such women were exceptions, however—for the most part, even female monarchs left military leadership, and the fighting itself, to male generals.

▼ Fearless fighter

Tomoe Gozen was a female warrior (*onna-bugeisha*) who rose to fame fighting in the Genpei War, a civil conflict between Japan's clans. She led male warriors into battle and was accomplished with both the bow and the sword.



PROFILES

VALIANT WARRIORS

Artemisia I of Caria (c. 5th century BCE) ruled the city-state of Halicarnassus (present-day Turkey) and several Aegean islands. When the Persian Emperor Xerxes launched an invasion of Greece in 480 BCE, she joined his forces. She advised Xerxes not to engage the Greek fleet at Salamis but he ignored her, and suffered a major defeat. Artemisia commanded a squadron of ships and survived the battle, ruling Caria until her death.

The Trung Sisters (d. 43 CE), Trac and Nhi, were born in northern Vietnam at a time when it was dominated by the Chinese Han Dynasty. After the Chinese executed Trac's husband, she and her sister began to agitate against their foreign overlords. In 39 CE the sisters led a popular rebellion against Han rule, gaining control of much of northern Vietnam. The Han quashed the uprising, and in 43 CE the sisters drowned themselves to avoid defeat.

Dihya al-Kahina (c. 7th century CE) was the daughter of a Berber chieftain. In the 680s she emerged as leader of the Berber tribes who joined together to resist the Arab Empire in its expansion into the Maghreb. Dubbed "Queen of the Berbers," she inflicted a major defeat on the Arabs, forcing them to retreat. They returned, and in around 702 Dihya was defeated and possibly killed in battle.

Olga of Kiev (d. 969) was married to Igor, King of the Kievan Rus', an East Slavic state. When her husband died in 945 Olga became regent. Refusing to remarry, she led military campaigns against opposition tribes and defeated rebels. In 968, while her son was away campaigning, she defended Kiev from invasion by nomads from Central Asia.

Matilda of Tuscany (1046–1115) was the daughter of a powerful northern Italian prince. After he was assassinated in 1052 she inherited his lands, which she successfully fought to maintain control of—even donning full armor to lead her armies in person.

Joanna of Flanders (c. 1295–1374), Duchess of Brittany, was a fierce military leader in the War of the Breton Succession from 1341 to 1365. She took up arms to secure the position of first her husband and then son, riding into town and encouraging local women to cut their skirts and join the fight. After leading the charge to burn down an enemy camp, she was known as "Jeanne la Flamme."